

Characterizing the γ -ray sky using differentiable probabilistic programming

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Abstract

We use differentiable probabilistic programming, enabled by recent advances in machine learning, in order to account for the large model-space inherent to γ -ray analyses in a principled manner. Focusing on the ongoing mystery of the Galactic Center Excess (GCE), we construct a differentiable forward model and likelihood that liberally uses GPU acceleration and vectorization in order to simultaneously account for a range of possible spatial morphologies consistent with the Excess emission. Our setup allows for efficient inference over the large model space using variational methods. The goal of this work is to enable analyses that are more robust to specific modeling choices compared to traditional techniques, and to provide a framework for future analyses.

1. Introduction

Analysis of γ -ray data towards the Galactic Center involves a subtle interplay between observations and theoretical models. The complexity of cosmic-ray transport processes in the region, combined with the fact that we only have access to a two-dimensional projection of this inherently three-dimensional process, means that we typically cannot make precise predictions about crucial emission mechanisms. Consequently, scientific conclusions drawn from γ -ray analyses can depend strongly on specific assumptions made about the modeling of the signal and background, as well as manual choices involved in the data analysis pipeline.

The γ -ray Galactic Center Excess (GCE), first identified over a decade ago (Goodenough & Hooper, 2009) using public data from the *Fermi* -LATE telescope (Atwood et al., 2009), is an excess of photons in the Inner Galaxy whose physical origin is currently unknown. Although the GCE has properties broadly compatible with those expected from an-

ihilating dark matter (DM) (Goodenough & Hooper, 2009; Hooper & Goodenough, 2011; Daylan et al., 2016; Calore et al., 2015; Ajello et al., 2016), competing explanations in terms of a population of unresolved astrophysical point sources (PSs), in particular millisecond pulsars (MSPs), remain viable (Abazajian et al., 2014; Abazajian, 2011). Significant effort has gone into characterizing the GCE and understanding its origin, including through inferring the properties of unresolved PSs in the Inner Galaxy region. A particularly successful method in this direction, Non-Poissonian Template Fitting (NPTF), aims to characterize different populations of unresolved PSs using their photon statistics, via a likelihood-based analysis (Lee et al., 2015; 2016). In the context of the GCE, initial applications of this method showed overwhelming support for the hypothesis of the GCE being sourced by an unresolved population of PSs spatially correlated with the observed GCE morphology (Lee et al., 2016). However, more recent studies showed the method to be susceptible to systematic biases (Leane & Slatyer, 2019; 2020a;b; Chang et al., 2020) partly stemming from degeneracies between different emission components in the region (e.g., those spatially correlated with the GCE, centrally-concentrated stellar populations, and the Galactic disk), with results depending strongly on specific assumptions made about the spatial morphologies of components. *All NPTF analyses so far have assumed inflexible, spatially rigid templates, preventing a rigorous expression and exploration of this degeneracy.*

In this work, we use differentiable probabilistic programming to alleviate this shortcoming of traditional likelihood-based fitting techniques for analyzing γ -ray data. Using GPU-native acceleration and vectorization, we construct a forward model for γ -ray emission in the Galactic Center region that can generate high-resolution spatial templates for various emission components, including those associated with the Galactic Center excess signal, on the fly. This allows for analyses that are robust to specific analysis choices, and opens up the possibility of performing model-independent analyses using the framework. In the broader context of astrophysics, this work aims to motivate the use of differentiable probabilistic programming as a way to enable high-dimensional Bayesian inference for complex descriptions of diverse astrophysical data.

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2. Methodology

We describe our forward model and likelihood, its implementation as a differentiable probabilistic program, as well as the inference strategies used to perform Bayesian posterior inference over the model parameters characterizing various emission mechanisms for Galactic Center γ -ray data.

2.1. The likelihood and forward model

In traditional template fitting, photon counts in different pixels p are modeled as Poisson random variables, with mean given by a linear combination of templates T_i^p , indexed i ; $x^p \sim \text{Pois}(x^p | \sum_i A_i T_i^p)$. A_i are the template normalizations and represent the parameters of interest. The full map-levels likelihood factorizes into a produce of pixel-wise likelihoods, $p(x | \{A_i\}) = \prod_p p(x_p | \{A_i\})$.

In the presence of populations of unresolved point sources, the likelihood can be augmented to take into account the probability that a given pixel contains a point source from a given population, and the probability of that point source emitting a certain mean number of contributing photons. Point source populations can be independently characterized by a spatial distribution, specified by a template $T_{\text{PS},i}^p$, and a source-count distribution dN/dS , which jointly describes the distribution of photon counts S from individual PSs, $p(S | \theta_{\text{PS}})$, and their mean abundance, $\bar{n}_{\text{PS}}$; $dN/dS = \bar{n}_{\text{PS}} p(S | \theta_{\text{PS}})$.

Unfortunately, the inclusion of point source populations renders the likelihood intractable, since computing it would involve marginalizing over positions, counts, and cardinality of point sources from each population. The NPTF method (Lee et al., 2015; 2016) circumvents this issue by instead computing the pixel-wise likelihood, and approximating the full likelihood as $p(x | \bar{n}_{\text{PS}}, \theta_{\text{PS}}) = \prod_p p(x^p | \bar{n}_{\text{PS}}, \theta_{\text{PS}})$. See Mishra-Sharma et al. (2017) for further details on the method. We implement a differentiable version of the NPTF likelihood in the Jax framework (Bradbury et al., 2018), making liberal use of vectorization and automatic batching to efficiently compute the likelihood for multiple point source populations.

2.2. Flexible specification of point source populations

Previous analyses based on the NPTF framework assumed rigidly specified spatial templates for the distribution of point source populations; this is because generating new morphologies adds to considerable overhead in the likelihood calculation, rendering a traditional Monte Carlo sampling-based analysis difficult. In particular, given a morphology for the PS template, $\rho(R, z)$ (assumed cylindrically symmetric), computing the template expectation in a give pixel p involves doing a line-of-sight integral in

the pixel direction, $T_{\text{PS}}^p = \int dl \rho(R(l, p), z(l, p))$. In Jax, the density over the line of sight as well across the pixel index can be efficiently vectorized, and the computation is just-in-time (JIT) compiled for efficient execution on a GPU.

This allows us to include parametric variations on different spatial templates that have been previously included in NPTF analyses, including templates for PSs correlated with the Galactic disk and the GCE, directly as part of the inference pipeline. We model a PS population with a generalized NFW profile, $\rho_{\text{gNFW}}(r) \propto (r/r_s)^{-\gamma} (1 + r/r_s)^{-3+\gamma}$ with the inner slope γ a free parameter to be inferred during the analysis. We also model a population of PSs spatially correlated with the Galactic disk, modeled as a double exponential, $\rho_{\text{disk}}(R, z) \propto (R/R_\odot)^B \exp[-C(R - R_\odot)/R_\odot] \exp(-|z|/z_s)$ with the parameter B , C , and the scale height z_s characterizing the disk morphology and to be inferred during the analysis.

The possibility of a population of PSs correlated with the stellar density in the Galactic bulge has been extensively tested in the literature (Macias et al., 2018; 2019; Ploeg et al., 2020), and either substantiated or disfavored depending on the analysis. We allow for this possibility in our analysis by including multiple publicly-available spatial templates following stellar bulge populations (Macias et al., 2018; 2019). For both the PS as well as smooth (Poissonian) components describing the GCE, we model the spatial distribution as a hybrid template allowing for varying fractions of DM-like and bulge-like morphologies, $T_{\text{GCE}}^p = (1 - f_{\text{bulge}})T_{\text{DM}}^p + f_{\text{bulge}}T_{\text{bulge}}^p$. The bulge template itself is modeled as a linear combination of publicly available bulge morphologies, $T_{\text{bulge}}^p = \sum_i \alpha_i T_{\text{bulge},i}^p$ with α_i modeled with a symmetric Dirichlet prior, enforcing $\sum_i \alpha_i = 1$. The templates are appropriately normalized such that an un-scaled template would produce a single count-per-pixel, allowing for a physically-meaningful interpretation of the bulge fraction f_{bulge} parameter as the relative contribution to the GCE PS or smooth component from the composite bulge component.

2.3. Parameter posterior inference

Since the entire pipeline from template generation to likelihood evaluation is end-to-end differentiable, we can evaluate gradients of the log-likelihood function with respect to the parameters of interest θ characterizing the smooth as well as PS components, $\nabla_\theta \log \mathcal{L}(\theta)$, with minimal overhead. This opens up the possibility of using highly efficient gradient-based posterior inference techniques like Stochastic Variational Inference (SVI) (Hoffman et al., 2012) and Hamiltonian Monte Carlo (HMC) (Hoffman & Gelman, 2011). Unlike traditional sampling techniques employed in the context of *Fermi* GCE analyses so far, these methods can

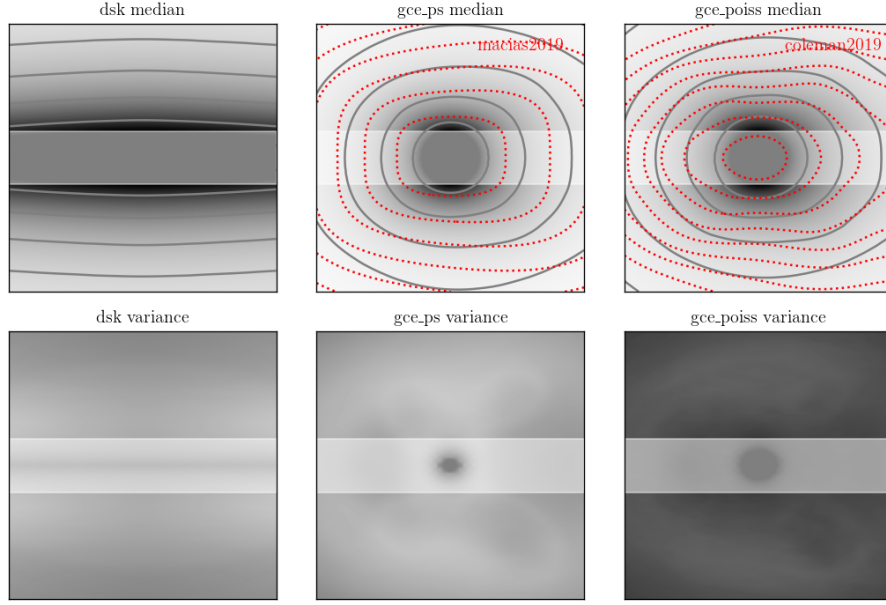


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easily scale up to high-dimensional parameter spaces. In particular, variational methods turn posterior inference into an optimization problem by fitting for a flexible functional ansatz on the posterior density and can easily deal with hundreds of parameters. This is in contrast to current public implementations of NPTF, which cannot efficiently include real-time generated templates at inference and are restricted to a modest number of parameters with traditional Monte Carlo sampling techniques. The constructed likelihood is wrapped using the probabilistic programming framework NumPyro (Phan et al., 2019), which allows for flexible specification of complex models as well as performing inference on them using gradient-based techniques.

In stochastic variational inference (SVI) an approximation for the posterior distribution, parameterized by φ and denoted $q_\varphi(\theta)$, is obtained by minimizing the reverse KL-divergence between the true and variational posterior distributions, $D_{\text{KL}}(q_\varphi || p(\theta | x))$. This is done by maximizing the model log-evidence $\log p(x)$ or, in practice using the tractable evidence lower bound (ELBO), $\text{ELBO} \equiv \mathbb{E}_{\theta \sim q_\varphi(\theta)} [\log p(x, \theta) - \log q_\varphi(\theta)]$, as the optimization objective since $\log p(x) - \text{ELBO} = D_{\text{KL}}(q_\varphi || p(\theta | x))$. The expectation in the ELBO is taken through Monte Carlo sampling from the variational distribution at each optimization step.

Since we’d like to be able to model arbitrarily flexible non-Gaussian posterior distributions, the variational family q_φ is modeled using an inverse autoregressive normalizing flow (IAF). The variational parameters—the parameters of the normalizing flow transformation—are optimized using Optax (Hessel et al., 2020) with the AdamW optimizer (Kingma & Ba, 2014; Loshchilov & Hutter, 2017) over 10,000 steps with learning rate 10^{-3} . Optimization typically takes ~ 10 minutes on a single Nvidia A100 GPU.

3. Experiments and results

We apply our pipeline to 573 weeks of *Fermi* -LAT data in the 2–20 GeV energy range. Smooth templates corresponding to isotropically-uniform emission, emission from (revolved) point sources in the 3FGL catalog, and the *Fermi* bubbles are included. Three different diffuse models – Models ‘A’ and ‘F’ from Calore et al. (2015) and Model ‘O’ from Macias et al. (2019) – are used to model the Galactic diffuse foreground emission, with the gas-correlated emission and Galactic charge density-correlated emission separately allowed be linear combinations of the corresponding components of the three templates.

Summaries of the inferred posteriors for disk-correlated PS, GCE-correlated PS, and GCE-correlated smooth emission

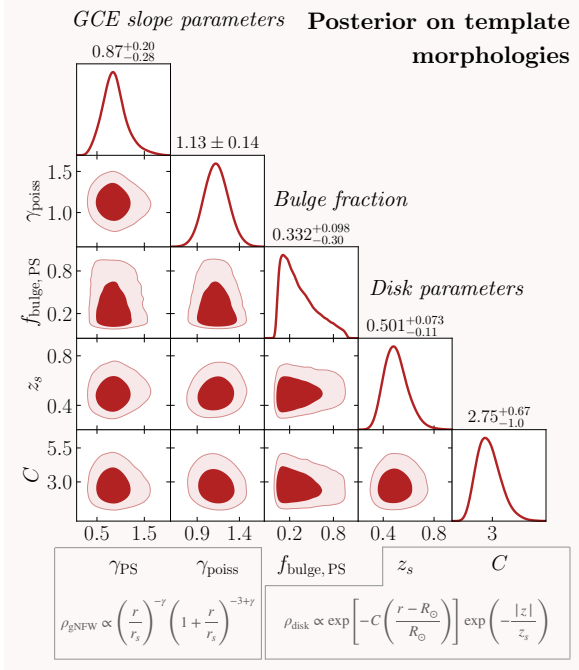


Figure 2. Posteriors on select parameters characterizing the GCE and disk PS morphologies obtained by analyzing *Fermi* -LAT data in the Inner Galaxy. The bulge fraction f_{bulge} , distributions on the NFW inner slopes γ for the PS and smooth NFW profiles, as well as select parameters characterizing the disk morphology are shown.

morphologies are shown in Fig. 1. The top row shows the median inferred pixel-wise morphologies, which the bottom row shows the relative middle-68% deviation of the posterior from the median (heuristically, the ‘1- σ ’ range of the posterior distribution). Contours for the best-fitting bulge-correlated component are shown using dotted red lines. It can be seen that, for both PS-like as well as smooth emission, the inferred posterior median is fairly spherically symmetric; this reflects a general preference for DM-like morphologies in our analyses. We emphasize that we obtain a full posterior distribution over preferred signal morphologies, departing significantly from the rigid parametric descriptions used in previous works.

Figure 2 shows posteriors on select parameters characterizing the GCE and disk PS morphologies. The bulge fraction $f_{\text{bulge}} = 0.332^{+0.10}_{-0.30}$ quantitatively substantiates a not-insignificant preference for a DM-like morphology in the GCE emission. Posteriors on the NFW inner slopes γ for the PS and smooth NFW profiles, as well as select parameters characterizing the disk morphology are shown.

4. Discussion and outlook

Using differentiable probabilistic programming techniques, we have introduced a scalable and flexible pipeline for disentangling the contribution of various emission sources to the γ -ray sky. The pipeline makes extensive use of the seamless vectorization, automatic differentiation, just-in-time compilation, and GPU acceleration enabled by the Jax framework as well as the flexible model specification and inference capabilities of the NumPyro framework.

While we have assumed parametric or physically-derived morphologies for the spatial distribution of various point source populations, using this pipeline we will be able to characterize Galactic Center in a fully signal model-independent manner, by scanning over a space of spatial *functions* on the sky map e.g., using Gaussian processes to define the function prior. A similar Gaussian process-based technique was successfully implemented in [Mishra-Sharma & Cranmer \(2020\)](#) to augment the morphology of the diffuse foreground template. The inclusion of flexible spatial templates in the pipeline is enabled by the highly efficient and differentiable version of the NPTF likelihood.

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